VC10X

VC10X PLAYBOOK · CHECKLIST

The Fundraising Checklist

35 steps for raising a first venture fund, organized by the seven stages of a raise, from testing demand before you quit to the final close.

From the VC10X playbook *How to Raise a Venture Fund*, built from on-record conversations with emerging managers, a fundraising adviser and allocators.

Before you launch

Work through stages 1 to 4. Anything you can't tick is your work list before the first LP meeting.

During the raise

Use stages 5 to 7 and the weekly tracker at the end. Measure conversations and introductions, not dollars.

Read the full playbook: vc10x.com/playbooks/how-to-raise-a-venture-fund

AT A GLANCE

The seven stages

Skipping a stage rarely saves time; it usually shows up later as a stalled raise.

#	STAGE	THE QUESTION TO ANSWER	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
1	**Before you quit**	Is there a fund here?	Soft commitments you've tested, and a few deals done with your own money
2	**Positioning**	Why you, and not an established firm?	A specialization and a story only you can tell
3	**Fund size and structure**	What's the right Fund I?	Big enough to prove the strategy, small enough to close
4	**Who to target**	Which LPs will actually back a first fund?	A short list of LPs that fit your size, stage and story
5	**Outreach**	How do you get the meeting?	Warm intros, common ground, and many conversations started at once
6	**Meetings and momentum**	How do you keep LPs moving?	A next step agreed at the end of every call
7	**Closing**	How do you get to final close?	Several closes, a clear date, and a steady weekly process

Test before you leap

Soft commitments and a few warehoused deals tell you whether there's a fund here.

Batch your outreach

Twenty conversations started together build momentum; two a week don't.

Close what you have

A first close lets you invest, and shows hesitant LPs the fund is real.

STAGE 1 OF 7

Before you quit

Is there a fund here?

What good looks like: Soft commitments you've tested, and a few deals done with your own money

- [ ] 1 List everyone who might back you, with a soft-commitment amount for each.
- [ ] 2 Estimate what share will convert at a first close.
- [ ] 3 Make two or three investments with your own money that match the strategy.
- [ ] 4 Budget for at least a year of costs before management fees arrive.
- [ ] 5 Decide how you'll fund the management company in the meantime.

STAGE 2 OF 7

Positioning

Why you, and not an established firm?

What good looks like: A specialization and a story only you can tell

- [ ] 6 Write your positioning in one sentence no established firm could say.
- [ ] 7 Explain why your background leads to this strategy.
- [ ] 8 Open your deck with your story, not your résumé.
- [ ] 9 Show what the firm looks like by Fund IV.
- [ ] 10 Cut any theme you can't show you knew before it was popular.

STAGE 3 OF 7

Fund size and structure

What's the right Fund I?

What good looks like: Big enough to prove the strategy, small enough to close

- [ ] 11 Work out the smallest fund that proves the strategy, and why.
- [ ] 12 Check the size against your check sizes, ownership targets and reserves.
- [ ] 13 Decide your GP commitment, and whether it's cash or funded from fees.
- [ ] 14 Engage fund administration, audit and legal counsel.
- [ ] 15 Decide solo or partnership, and how you'll cover what you can't do yourself.

STAGE 4 OF 7

Who to target

Which LPs will actually back a first fund?

What good looks like: A short list of LPs that fit your size, stage and story

- [ ] 16 Write your ideal LP profile: type, check size, sector link, appetite for first funds.
- [ ] 17 Build a target list that fits that profile.
- [ ] 18 Find each LP's minimum check before the first meeting.
- [ ] 19 Check funds of funds' own fundraising timing.
- [ ] 20 Keep a separate list of large LPs to meet for later funds.

STAGE 5 OF 7

Outreach

How do you get the meeting?

What good looks like: Warm intros, common ground, and many conversations started at once

- [ ] 21 Send your target list to your network and ask for specific introductions.
- [ ] 22 Ask other GPs and existing LPs who they can introduce you to.
- [ ] 23 Write first emails around common ground, not the fund.
- [ ] 24 Start around 20 conversations within the same couple of weeks.
- [ ] 25 Publish something that lets LPs hear your story before you meet.

STAGE 6 OF 7

Meetings and momentum

How do you keep LPs moving?

What good looks like: A next step agreed at the end of every call

- [ ] 26 Use the first meeting to establish fit, and listen more than you talk.
- [ ] 27 Plan what each of the first three meetings will cover.
- [ ] 28 End every call with a dated next step.
- [ ] 29 Have your track record, deal list, references and memos ready.
- [ ] 30 Complete a standard due diligence questionnaire before you're asked.

STAGE 7 OF 7

Closing

How do you get to final close?

> **What good looks like:** Several closes, a clear date, and a steady weekly process

- [ ] 31 Hold a first close as soon as you can start investing.
- [ ] 32 Decide what early LPs receive for committing first.
- [ ] 33 Set weekly targets for conversations and introductions.
- [ ] 34 Set a close date, communicate it and stick to it.
- [ ] 35 Plan quarterly reporting before the final close.

DURING THE RAISE

Weekly tracker

Track inputs you control. Commitments follow conversations, usually months later.

WEEK	NEW LPS CONTACTED	INTROS RECEIVED	MEETINGS HELD	NEXT STEPS AGREED	COMMITMENTS
Week 1					
Week 2					
Week 3					
Week 4					
Week 5					
Week 6					
Week 7					
Week 8					
Week 9					
Week 10					
Week 11					
Week 12					

Built from conversations with

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Keep going

The full playbook vc10x.com/playbooks/how-to-raise-a-venture-fund

Fundraising Readiness Audit vc10x.com/fundraising-audit

LP Fit Audit vc10x.com/lp-fit-audit

Venture Manager Scorecard vc10x.com/manager-scorecard

Fund Economics Calculator vc10x.com/fund-economics-calculator

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